

States BIHAR

court's order giving decisive pre-eminence to citizens' consent in the location of a liquor shop is a defining moment. Now, government authorities across the state will have to mention in black and white if a particular shop has been approved by residents or not," he claims.

What the lawyer leaves unsaid is that this can make Nitish Government's overzealous excise policy fall flat on its face; as practically no shop has been settled in Bihar—now or before—by following all provisions of the Excise Act. For instance, Rule 48 of the Act stipulates that a prior

hand, determine more pertinent economic and social factors with Bihar's growing obsession with the spirit. Though unemployment levels are high, thanks to the new policy, liquor is now affordable and easily available at one's doorstep. The social impact has already begun to be felt, especially in rural areas where the consumption of liquor by teenagers has risen. According to the Bihar Economic Survey, the share of revenue from country-made liquor in both 2006-07 and 2007-08 was more than what Indian Made Foreign Liquor gener-

spurious liquor claimed six lives in November last year alone, and now with liquor being served freely, more innocent lives are at stake.

The Government, however, seems viewing the issue with soft bifocals. The state Excise Minister Jamshed Asraf appears hooked to Bihar's potential to "double the existing revenue." A section of activists, however, say that though the Government claims to spend the

(LEFT) SEVEN HOUSEWIVES' EFFORTS HELPED GET A LIQUOR SHOP SHIFTED; MANY SHOPS ARE LOCATED NEXT TO SCHOOLS AND COLLEGES.

RANJAN RAHI



ACTING ON THE COMPLAINT OF CITIZENS, THE PATNA HIGH COURT HAS SOUGHT REPORTS ON WHETHER EXCISE RULES HAVE BEEN FOLLOWED.

notice must be circulated among residents to seek their concurrence before allowing settlement of a liquor shop in that area. The rule also has an elaborate list of places (bathing ghats, educational and religious institutions, hospitals, petrol pump, railway station, labour colony and places of public resort) close to which a liquor shop cannot be settled. "Over a dozen liquor shops which were earlier located near schools and temples have already been relocated," says Mangalam. Observers believe that the excise authorities have flagrantly violated many rules.

Social scientists, on the other

ated during this period.

Traditionally, drinking was never really an integral part of Bihar's rural landscape despite its feudal hang-ups, but the recent spurt in availability of spicy country liquor is enticing the poor to splurge on it as an escape from depressing realities and in turn fall prey to it. Though the per capita consumption of liquor in the state is on the rise, the Excise and Prohibition Department still seems to be indifferent. The argument is that the new policy would help eliminate illicit liquor trade and there would be no spurious wine left in the market. This hasn't happened so far, as

revenue generated from liquor sales on the welfare programmes, it seems to be ignoring the fact that the social fabric is under strain and citizens' health can be a casualty, thanks to free-flowing liquor. The state, however, counters the problem of alcoholism with dismissive sarcasm and black humour. Though the Excise Department commands a prominent position in terms of maximising revenues wherewithal, Nitish appears far from emulating his mentor, the late Karpoori Thakur, who had introduced prohibition during his tenure as the chief minister in 1977.



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